UNSEEN

The Invisible Work Behind Every Overnight Success



Muyaka Ngulube-Banda

2
The Messenger

Whenever my siblings needed something from our father, I was the one sent to ask.

I was daddy's girl.

Named after his mother. That gave me a place nobody else had. My father had a soft spot for me, unspoken but seen in action. I was the one he reached for. The one who sat in when he was relaxing in the family room and watched some of my favourite soaps and football matches with him.

But being the favourite came with a job.

Whenever my siblings needed something from our father, I was the one sent to ask. Not because I was the oldest. Not because I was the boldest. Because I was the one he was most likely to say yes to or simply tolerate.

When the answer was yes, I brought good news. When the answer was no, I stood there and caught it. Scoldings. Proper ones. The kind that stays with you longer than the moment.

I was a child. I did not question it. Privileges come with conditions. I accepted the terms because I did not know there were other terms available.

After a while I stopped minding the scoldings. That should have worried me.

Something was hardening in me. I mistook it for toughness. It would take years to show me what it actually was.

Then I reached Grade 8 and my father decided it was time for boarding school.

He found places for my brother and me at a school in the eastern part of Zambia. He drove us there himself. I remember the drive being long, not knowing what I was getting into.

The comfort was that my brother was with me. Whatever challenge lay ahead, I told myself my brother would be there to help. That thought held me the whole drive.

Before we arrived at the school my father made a detour. He branched off to visit a long-time friend. A headmaster at a different school. A man who had been at teaching college with him. They knew each other. My father also had a teaching background so he wanted to say hello.

We all went to the headmaster's office. They talked. They had a good laugh. Then the man looked at me and said something that changed everything.

Why don't you leave the girl here he asked? This is a stricter school. Let the boy go to the other school. I have space for the girl.

I was shaking my head. No. I just want to go with my brother.

My father did not even speak to me. He just decided. We leave you here. The boy proceeds.

That was it. They walked out. My brother walked out with my father. I stood there. There were no cell phones then. There was no calling home. There was no reaching anyone.

I literally felt like I had been left in the middle of nowhere.

I had imagined settling in with my brother. Being reachable. Having someone familiar in a strange place. Instead, I was in a school I had not chosen in a town I did not know with people I had never met. Communal rooms. Communal bathrooms. No power at night. Everything strange. Everything new.

That was the beginning. I just did not know of what.

Something started that day. Something I would carry for the rest of my life. I did not know it then. I was just trying to survive the first night.

Like me, many of us find ourselves carrying roles we did not choose long before we are old enough to question them. The child who becomes the messenger in the family. The one who gets sent. The one who gets blamed. The one who absorbs the response so others do not have to.

Or the child who gets left somewhere. Not asked. Not consulted. Just left. Told this is how it is. Told to manage. And the child manages because that is what children do. They do not negotiate. They adapt.

We carry these roles into adulthood without realising they were never assignments. They were formations. The environment shaped us before we had the language to resist it. By the time we are old enough to question what happened to us the shaping is already done.

The question is not whether you were formed. You were. The question is what was deposited.

Two things were deposited in me before I knew they were building.

The first was independence. Not the kind you choose. The kind that is chosen for you. I did not decide to walk to school across a road parents feared. I did not decide to be the one sent to ask. I did not decide to be left at a school in the eastern province. These things happened. I adapted. Layer by layer. Without permission. Each separation made the next one possible. Each one taught me I could survive without what I thought I needed.

I did not know I had this independence until the moment I needed it. By then it had been holding me for years. South Sudan. Nigeria. Indonesia. Liberia. Timor Leste. Five countries. Each one alone. Each time I reached for someone familiar. Each time there was no one. Each time I did not fall.

The second was capacity. Not toughness. Capacity. The capacity to stand between what someone needs and the person who can provide it without breaking. Being the messenger taught me this. The closer you are to the person who can say yes, the closer you are to the person who can say no. You carry someone else's need. You absorb the response. Whatever it is. You feel both sides. The asking and the

answering. You are the one in between.

None of this felt like training while it was happening. It felt like life. That is how the best formation works. You do not see it. You just live through it.

My brother was never the reason I survived boarding school.

He was the reason I had courage on the drive. He was the reason I thought I would be fine. But one headmaster took that from me in one sentence. My father let it happen in silence. I was alone from the first day.

That was the gift. Not the brother. The lonesomeness.

The headmaster did me a favour that day. He took away the safety net before I knew I had one. What was left was the thing that actually held me. The independence that was being built long before that office. The walk to school had put it there. Being sent to ask had put it there. The headmaster just revealed it by taking everything else away.

Boarding school did not teach me independence. It forced me to use what was already there.

And the thing I mistook for toughness?

It was not toughness. It was capacity. Every international posting, I have held has been the same job I had at eight years old. Carrying the ask. Absorbing the response. Holding steady when the answer is no.

I did not learn that in a boardroom. I learned it in my father's house. Standing in front of a man who had the power. Carrying a request that was not mine. Taking the scolding that came with the no. Not running.

You do not get to choose your formation. You do not get to opt out of the things that build you. You just live through them.

The walk to school. The scoldings. The headmaster's office. The brother walking out the door. None of it felt like training. It felt like life. Ordinary. Unremarkable. This is just how it is.

But one day you land in a country where you know no one and you do not panic. You walk into a room where you are the only woman and the only African and you do not crumble. You carry a message between people who do not trust each other and you do not break.

You realise that everything you endured without understanding was depositing something you would need.

I was a girl being built. I did not know it. But the building did not need my permission.

The building gave me infrastructure. But infrastructure needs a door. In 1998 I walked through one. My first qualification. My first office.

A woman who already worked there looked at me and said something I have never forgotten.

That is where the building begins.

The rest of the story

UNSEEN follows the seasons that came after this one: the marriage that looked complete and was quietly breaking, the body that said what the mouth would not, the pastor who named it, and the four steps that turned twenty years of unseen work into a life that no longer has to prove itself.

Order the book and receive the Seasons Reflection Guide free.

Available on Amazon in Kindle and paperback.

www.muyakangulubebanda.com

"There is no access without process. Your season is not a verdict. It is a setup."

Muyaka Ngulube-Banda

© 2026 Muyaka Ngulube-Banda. This chapter is shared for reading. Please do not reproduce or distribute it.